OFFICIAL PARTICIPANT RULEBOOK

THE HIDDEN KEY

Six days. One cryptographic repository.

Dive into the source. Decode the mystery. Claim First Blood.

YOUR MISSION

Investigate an encrypted challenge repository created by **APPISTRY (App Development Club, STC IIT Patna Hybrid)**. Examine the riddle clues published on the live stage, deduce the 3-part passphrase, run the offline terminal unlock utility, and submit the authentic secret keyword to claim the legendary **First Blood Bounty**.

REGISTRATION	CHALLENGE DATES	FIRST BLOOD BOUNTY
28 OCT – 1 NOV	2 – 7 NOV	HALL OF FAME
2026 • IIT PATNA ONLY	2026 • SIX-DAY HUNT	TROPHY & RECOGNITION

THE CASE & YOUR ROLE

The Investigation

Understand the case. Follow the evidence. Compete independently.

01 What is The Hidden Key?

THE HIDDEN KEY is a six-day online cryptographic mystery hunt conceived and hosted by **APPISTRY (App Development Club, STC IIT Patna Hybrid)**. Participants examine a specially prepared open-source repository containing source code, package configurations, commit logs, and an encrypted artifact. The objective is to connect the clues, deduce the authentic three-part passphrase, execute the offline unlock utility, and register the authentic keyword on the live leaderboard.

02 How the investigation works

- **Clues Released Progressively:** Riddles and cryptographic clues are published on the live stage without requiring code updates.
- **Three-Part Mystery Passphrase:** The solution connects technical club identity, regional legacy, and the hybrid future.
- **Offline Terminal Decryption:** Participants clone the codebase and execute `npm run unlock`. The CLI derives an AES-256-GCM key using the Scrypt KDF to authenticate and decrypt the sealed artifact locally.
- **Instant Atomic Ranking:** Submitting the revealed keyword on the web portal registers an atomic server timestamp, locking your official rank.

No spoilers in this rulebook • Fair Play Policy

Any examples or riddles shown in promotional banners are strictly illustrative. The true clues, commit trails, and encryption salt reside exclusively in official releases and live broadcasts. Sharing discovered passphrases publicly spoils the challenge and results in immediate disqualification.

03 Participation rules

By registering and participating, you agree to the rules below. They keep the mystery hunt fair, safe, and enjoyable for all IIT Patna students:

- **Individual Entry:** Each participant competes independently. Team submissions, shared accounts, and proxy submissions are prohibited.
- **Official @iitp.ac.in Credentials:** Participation is strictly limited to verified students of IIT Patna using their official college email.
- **Single Submission:** Each participant is allowed exactly **one verified submission**. Double-check your keyword before submitting.
- **Rate-Limiting Protection:** The portal enforces a 20 submissions/minute rate limit. Automated script hammering will trigger automatic IP blacklisting.
- **Keep Answers Private:** Do not share decrypted keys, unreleased clues, or solution screenshots with other participants while the event is live.
- **Be Honest & Ethical:** Do not impersonate other students, tamper with network packets, or manipulate timestamps.

TOOLS & FAIR PLAY

Investigate Responsibly

Use developer tools thoughtfully and stay within the official challenge environment.

04 AI and Developer Tools

AI tools are permitted as assistants

You may use LLMs such as ChatGPT, Claude, and Gemini, alongside Git terminal commands, Node.js scripts, and browser developer tools to inspect and analyze the materials. However, you remain entirely responsible for the final answer.

- **Cryptographic Ground Truth:** All answers must pass authentic AES-256-GCM authenticated tag verification. AI hallucinations will fail Scrypt key derivation.
- **Do Not Fabricate Keys:** Submitting random or speculative guesses wastes your single official submission opportunity.
- **Zero Points for Prompts:** Evaluation is strictly binary—either the secret keyword is cryptographically authentic, or it is not.
- **Finalist Verification:** Organizers reserve the right to request finalists to explain their investigative trail and deduction methodology.

05 Safety and permitted scope

- **Permitted Target:** Investigate only the repository code (`github.com/ravi-c029/appistry-the-hidden-key`) and the official live web application.
- **No Infrastructure Attacks:** Do not attack, port scan, overload, or attempt denial-of-service (DoS/DDoS) attacks against the Vercel hosting platform, submission API endpoints, or database clusters.
- **Offline Execution:** Run the `npm run unlock` CLI on your local development machine. It functions 100% offline and requires no internet calls.
- **Privacy & Respect:** Do not access, collect, or publish fellow participants' email addresses or personal information.

Immediate Disqualification Grounds

Automated brute-forcing of submission endpoints, impersonating another IIT Patna student, sharing solution keys in WhatsApp/Discord groups, or interfering with event services will result in immediate permanent disqualification.

SUBMISSIONS & WINNERS

Make Your Key Count

Accurate key verification. Microsecond timestamps. Permanent honor.

06 Honor & Bounty Structure

Finding the keyword alone is not enough—timeliness, accuracy, and server verification determine your standing on the official board.

CATEGORY	WHAT IS EVALUATED	HONOR / BOUNTY
First Blood Champion	First participant with valid verified submission on server	Trophy & Headline
Top 10 Finishers	Fastest valid submissions based on atomic server timestamps	Certificate of Excellence
Verified Solvers	All valid @iitp.ac.in submissions recorded before event close	Digital Certificate
TOTAL RECOGNITION	Microsecond-accurate ranking on live official leaderboard	100% Verified

07 How rankings are determined

- **Atomic Server Timestamps:** Rankings are ordered strictly by the atomic UTC timestamp recorded by the production database when your submission passes verification.
- **No Tie-Breakers Required:** High-precision server timestamps eliminate ties. Every millisecond counts.
- **Official Winner Announcement:** Final standings and certificate distribution will occur between **8 and 9 November 2026** through official APPISTRY channels.

08 Submitting your secret keyword

- **Submission Portal:** Navigate to `/submit` on the live web portal.
- **Enter Exact Details:** Provide your Full Name, official `@iitp.ac.in` email, and discovered keyword.
- **Case Sensitivity:** The secret keyword is case-sensitive and must match the terminal unlock output exactly.
- **Confirmation Receipt:** Upon successful submission, an on-screen confirmation badge and recorded timestamp will be displayed.

> **Before you submit**
> Ensure that your secret keyword was confirmed with "ACCESS GRANTED" by the offline CLI utility before submitting. You have only 1 official submission.